

## ENCOUNTER BETWEEN ETHNOLOGY AND SOCIOLOGY: THE CASE OF JOKING RELATIONSHIPS\*

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*Abstract* Ethnology and sociology have a long tradition of reciprocal contributions. Radcliffe-Brown's classic analysis of the 'joking relationship' between the maternal uncle and the nephew on the sister's side in certain South African tribes provides a useful point of departure for studying joking relationships in our modern societies. Inversely, observations on this subject made in our everyday environment help us to understand the psycho-social processes underlying certain habits, which otherwise seem confusing at first glance, in traditional societies. This interdisciplinary encounter points out the possibility of extracting general properties of social life if the appropriate level of abstraction is selected. Subsequently, we are faced with the problem of the relationship between model and reality. Here the theoretical intention of Lévi-Strauss approaches that of Simmel as expressed in modern terms by Boudon.

### 1. *Ethnology and sociology*

In the field of the social sciences, disciplinary boundaries have never been very stable. Sociologists, particularly, even while attempting to establish the specificity of the sociological approach, have never quite been able to suppress the dream of a global social science unworried by academic fiefdoms. This is perhaps not a bad thing; the sociological way of thinking has little difficulty adjusting to violations of interdisciplinary frontiers. Some of the great classics, after all, owe their existence to the fact that their authors were simultaneously sociologists, historians, and economists; philosophers as well, but that is another story... Moreover, Comtean systems of classification of sciences have failed. It is widely accepted today that both the material and the conceptual realms of each discipline must be taken into account (Piaget 1967 : 1173). In the case of the relationship between ethnology and sociology, these two essential criteria have proven to be particularly fluid.<sup>1</sup> Balandier has indicated several times that the very evolution of the societies which were traditionally the object of ethnological studies, as well as changes in attitudes about these societies, has led to putting 'scientific identity cards' into question (1971 : 5). On the one hand, a method<sup>2</sup> 'little respectful of the frontiers between ethnology and sociology' has developed (*ibid.*), while, on the other hand, it was recognised that knowledge accumulated about 'exterior' societies and

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cultures is pertinent to the study of our own societies (1974 : 9). Some of Radcliffe-Brown's analyses, among which are those undoubtedly bringing about a decisive qualitative leap in ethnology (Lévi-Strauss 1973 : 61), are of crucial importance here.

## 2. *The joking relationship among kin*

Studying diverse populations in Africa, Asia, Oceania and North America, Radcliffe-Brown was struck by what at first glance seems to the outside observer to be an extremely surprising kind of relationship. He regroups several relationships of this type under the rubric 'joking relationship', which he defines as 'a relation between two persons in which one is by custom permitted, and in some instances required, to tease or make fun of the other, who in turn is required to take no offence' (Radcliffe-Brown 1963 : 90). These relationships vary in symmetry. At one extreme, each partner teases the other. At the other extreme, *A* jokes at the expense of *B*, who accepts the teasing good-humouredly, but without retaliating. In intermediary cases one of the partners teases the other as much as he pleases, while the second teases only a little in return. This type of relationship also takes many different forms: sometimes it remains purely verbal, sometimes it includes horse-play and, in some instances, the joking may include elements of obscenity (ibid. : 90). The real significance of this behaviour can only be understood, and mistakes about the real intentions of the participants avoided, in context. The important feature of 'joking relationships' among kin is that the teasing – whatever the form it takes – is always a way of combining friendliness and antagonism. It is this very ambivalence which causes the measure of antagonism in the relationship to be expressed in the mitigated form of teasing. Although some differences remain as to the interpretation of particular cases, there now seems to be general agreement on this interpretation of the phenomenon. An individual belongs to a group. His or her relations with other group members are defined by norms associated with clear sanctions. Any relation with someone from outside the limits of the group will be subject to elements of misinterpretation and unpredictability which are potentially hostility-inducing. Thus the ambivalence of the relationships reflects the ambiguity of a situation in which two loyalties are combined: loyalty to the group of origin, and loyalty to the group with which a certain form of alliance has been established. Thus numerous joking relationships are formed between kin by alliance. Marriage, in fact, provides the typical example of the sort of situation described here: it implies that each of the spouses readjusts relationships with the family of origin, while enlarging the field of family relationships on the side of spouse and his or her kinship (ibid. : 91).

## 3. *A classical example: the avuncular relationship*

The best-known example – and the most interesting for our study – of the application of the kind of interpretation described above is that of the

relationship between maternal uncle and uterine nephew. Among peoples as different as the BaThonga (East Africa), the Nama (South Africa) and the Tonga (Polynesia), researchers have described a joking relationship between the mother's brother and the sister's son, in which great liberties may be taken (ibid. : 97 and ss). When observations were made, these three populations were patrilineally and patriarchally organised. During the whole of the nineteenth century, in the time of triumphant evolutionism, the peculiarities of the relationship between maternal uncle and uterine nephew in these cases were explained by postulating the existence of a previous matrilinear and/or matriarchal system. Radcliffe-Brown came to oppose interpretations founded on unsupported pseudo-historical reconstructions, and this marks the transition to the functionalist approach in this matter<sup>3</sup>. Incidentally, his study of the relationship between maternal uncle and uterine nephew in South Africa reflects full mastery of the use of function as an analytical tool<sup>4</sup>. Let us try to summarise the argument here. The populations considered are patrilinear, and there is no indication that they have not always been so. A man behaves toward his sister's son in a much more tolerant – today we would say permissive – way than toward his brother's sons or even toward his own sons. The uterine nephew is thus accorded a sort of 'privilege of disrespect' or 'of familiarity' towards the maternal uncle (ibid. : 97 and ss). The liberties taken by a son toward his mother's brother are generally accompanied by an attitude of respect and of submission toward his father's sister (ibid. : 98). Thus, each type of relationship appears as the logical complement of the other within a patrilinear system; the attitudes adopted toward the father and the mother are generalised to their respective brothers and sisters. From the mother's brother as from the mother – one can expect indulgence and affectionate protection. The model of comportment expected from a maternal uncle is one of a 'sort of male mother'. The father's sister, on the contrary, is perceived as a 'sort of female father', a perception reflected in kinship terminology (ibid. : 99). The corresponding behaviours are institutionalised. Thus an individual owes a father's sister obedience and respect, while he can expect great indulgence from the mother's brother. In the latter case, however, principles of seniority and of masculinity are in conflict with principles of lineage. Here we have – as one can see – a relationship loaded with internal contradictions. The tolerance generally attributed to a woman is expected from a man – and moreover, from a man of the preceding generation. In addition, affectivity crosses lineage boundaries. A relationship as complex as this carries latent tensions, which, in some cases, are dealt with by avoidance. In the case considered here, potential role conflicts are neutralised by the ritualisation of a joking relationship among kin (ibid. : 97 and ss).

For Radcliffe-Brown, the analysis we have just broadly sketched leads to 'a general theory of the social functions of respect and disrespect' (1963 : 98). What is of more interest to me here is to contribute to the elaboration of a theory of the role of joking in the interpersonal relationships. This could help advance a much wider ranging sociological theory of humour, a theory as yet

far from developed, although there are some scattered elements in the literature (Zijderveld 1971 and 1983).

It might be argued that, although the ethnological data available are undeniably rich, and the proposed interpretation is skilful, the above could only be of documentary interest. It concerns, after all, only populations very different from us, populations which in addition have been acculturated, or decimated, or are in the process of extinction. If this were the case there would not be much here that could help us learn about our own society, knowledge which could, as Balandier suggests, make 'our sociology more operational' (1974 : 9). What I would like to point out in this article is that knowledge accumulated by ethnologists about joking relationships is more generally pertinent than one might be tempted to think at first sight. Let us avoid naive ethnocentrism, however. Western societies have been marked by a general tendency towards individualisation and privatisation. In traditional societies, on the other hand, interpersonal relationships are more dependent on the membership of respective individuals in collectivities. In such a context the very notion of interindividual relationships, in the sense in which we conceive of and value it, has a completely different meaning. The importance of these modalities of social organisation should in no case be underestimated. But, beyond these differences, a perceptive observer who knows how to sort the essential from the peripheral should nonetheless be able to uncover general mechanisms of social life. In our developed Western societies no binding norm obliges us to generalise the attitude adopted towards one individual to all of his kin. There are, nevertheless, relationships which carry latent tensions. There are, in addition, behaviours which allow both the expression of these tensions and the limitation of their effects. And joking is, under certain circumstances, the sign of ambivalence in these situations. Of course, the sources of tension and of ambivalence are different. Consequently, the relationships which are the most pertinent for our study are no longer kinship relationships, but relationships grounded, at least normatively, in the reciprocal affinity of individual partners.

#### *4. Joking relationships in a modern context*

The data presented here are extracted from the analysis and comparison of some twenty *case studies* greatly dispersed over space and time. In the course of various peregrinations I have been able to make observations on which the confrontation with the ethnological perspective has conferred a sociological significance they would not otherwise have acquired. These observations, so conceptualised in the light of a previously existing structure of knowledge (Piaget 1967 : 1151), then reached a new cognitive status. They became data generative of new hypotheses within the framework of a current research programme on a wider theme<sup>5</sup>. Incidentally, as I have done previously (Coenen-Huther 1984b), and continue to do, I have cast a sociological eye on situations which were not originally conceived as occasions for research. I have explored the implications of this procedure elsewhere (ibid. : 191 and ss.).

What could be more tempting, indeed, than studying daily life ... in one's own daily environment.

All of the relationships presented here are seen by those involved as being friendship relationships. They correspond, to various degrees, to the model normatively associated with the notion of friendship in our modern Western societies: reciprocal relationships, based on personalities (and not on a category), voluntary (independent of agents of social control), created (not presupposed, for example, because of kinship ties), based on attraction and pleasure (the pleasure of being together, of doing things together) rather than being instrumental (the relationship is an end in itself). They tend, in addition, not to remain within the limits of certain selected roles, but to implicate the total personalities of the partners (Allan : 1979). They thus illustrate and reflect the model of the personalised friendship relation which constitutes a fact of our culture. They are all, however, *atypical*, relationships which are, in one way or another, exceptional. How are these relationships atypical? It has been empirically established that friendship relationships generally obey a principle of *homophily*. The term homophily can, as we might imagine, be traced to that of homogamy, and indicates 'a tendency for friendships to form between those who are alike in some designated respect' (Lazarsfeld and Merton 1954 : 23). As the saying goes, 'birds of a feather flock together'. This, after all, is fairly trite. What is less trite and more interesting for sociological analysis, is the distinction between *status-homophily* and *value-homophily*. Status-homophily is the observable – and observed – tendency for similarity between friends' group-affiliations, or between their positions within a group. Value-homophily is a tendency, also empirically established, toward correspondence of value-orientations and hierarchies of values between friends (ibid. : 24). These are merely statistical regularities, and this is not the place to present an explicative theory of them; we will perhaps have the opportunity to do so elsewhere. Of more interest for the present purposes are the exceptions to these general tendencies, the heterophilic friendships, whether they be of status, of values, or of both. Heterophilic friendships are thus friendships between individuals who, from one point of view or another, present divergent characteristics. These divergences could be in socio-professional position, in age, in nationality, etc. Separately or in combination, these different characteristics result in differences of status or of value-orientations. A common factor in all of these relationships is that joking is an essential element; either the relationship is experienced entirely on an ironic mode, or humour and teasing are central. Long-term observation of certain of these relationships makes one think that it is precisely the joking that keeps the relationship alive. When it is no longer possible to continue in a laughing mode, the relationship loses the diffuseness which made it a friendship and becomes more specific; it becomes more of a purely functional relation. When this happens, relationships sometimes cease completely.

After sketching a rudimentary typology of the relationships under study, we are led to think that the element to be neutralised by joking can always

eventually be traced to heterophily of status and/or of values. In some cases the conflict of values is directly apparent. In others the most obvious source of potential tension is a status difference. In some relationships these elements are translated into role ambiguity. At times value heterophily is seen in the form of a conflict of norms. This will now be described in detail.

*4.1 Value conflicts:* We can assume that the relationship has emerged on the basis of an apparent similarity of values, and that divergences appeared only at a later stage. That the partners have other characteristics in common suggests this interpretation, at least as a hypothesis. The matter at issue in a conflict can of course vary, as we shall see:

(a) *Work ethic:* The partners, although they have common interests, have fundamentally different attitudes toward work.

*Case I:* *A* and *B* are leftist political activists. Their ideas coincide on numerous points. *A* holds, however, a strongly internalised work ethic, which seems to him to be in no way incompatible with his socialist ideals, quite the contrary. *B*, on the other hand, cultivates an anarchist view of society, claims 'the right to be idle' and revolts against what seems to him to be the legitimization of 'the grind'. Their relationship is maintained on the basis of bantering about *A*'s professional environment. The initiative generally comes from *B*, but *A* plays along, simulating a detachment he does not really feel about his professional activities.

*Case II:* *A* and *B* are neighbours whose relationship has evolved towards a friendship relationship. *A* works regularly, while *B* gets along as he can. A relationship presenting the same formal characteristics as the preceding relationship develops between the two. Here, too, the target of the bantering is *A*'s work environment.

(b) *Contact between cultures:* *A* and *B* participate together in the same programme of developmental aid in a country of Black Africa. *A*'s motivation is idealistic, and he attempts to develop egalitarian relationships with the people of the host country. *B* was attracted by the material advantages of the assignment, but was not intellectually prepared for the culture shock. His attitude toward the local population is somewhat paternalistic. A joking relationship evolves between *A* and *B* in which *A* is the object of endless jeering from *B*. The latter suggests that *A*'s interest in the Africans is really based on a taste for African women... (*Case 4*).

(c) *Professional values:* The protagonists have the same professional activity. Their friendship stems from previously existing professional contacts:

*Case 16:* *A* and *B* are research workers. After years of professional life, *A* still keeps faith in research ethics, while *B* has become fairly lax in respect to norms of scientific activity. Even though he behaves differently, *A* is lucid enough to understand what has caused the evolution of *B*'s attitude. The two exchange

any number of cynical remarks about research circles. Since criticism is veiled by irony, one can never be entirely certain of the convictions of each.

Other situations are formally similar from the point of view taken here. *Case 7* concerns two teachers, one of whom is still very much dedicated to teaching, while the other delights in careless cynicism. *Case 18* involves two civil servants: one has a calling for public service, while the other is more attracted by employment security. *Case 20* opposes two doctors: one, expressed in Parsonian terms, collectivity-oriented and the other self-oriented.

In cases 1, 11 and 4 it is interesting to note that the relationships are asymmetrical in the sense used by Radcliffe-Brown. In each of these cases one of the partners is the victim of the jokes of the other. There is no reciprocity in the mockery. The one who is the object of the teasing accepts it willingly: his only parry is in playing along with it. To use the very pertinent distinction made by Eugène Dupréel (1949 : 41), a joking relationship, in this case, makes possible the transformation of an 'exclusion laugh' into a 'welcoming laugh'. By accepting compromise in an ironic mode, the individual subjected to teasing enters, so to speak, the circle of those who tease; one is no longer excluded by mockery. Case 16, on the contrary, illustrates a symmetrical relationship, as do the comparable cases 7, 18 and 20. Each of the partners conserves his own values, but the humour is not directed from one to the other: the social context is the common target. This is a case of the 'laugh of complicity'. There is a sort of 'mutual acknowledgement' that things are not exactly as one might have wished (Dupréel 1949 : 54-55).

#### 4.2 *Status differences*: Three distinct forms emerge:

(a) *A* is of higher status than *B*. The difference is such that professional interests can no longer serve as cement for the relationship, which does not have a specific leisure activity as a support either. The relationship is nevertheless pleasant and relaxing for the participants, and is valued as such. According to another formula of Dupréel, '*one finds one another again* to the detriment of the more stilted environment in which each is compelled to spend most of his time' (1949 : 54, author's emphasis, translated from the French). Relationships of this type were observed in case 5 (social worker and senior civil servant), 6 (hairdresser and jurist), 10 (salesman and historian) and 13 (international civil servant and lower level clerical worker). Here, also, the joking relationship is asymmetrical since one of the partners bears the brunt of the teasing. There is, however, a particularity: it is the person with the higher status who makes jokes at his own expense, evoking, for example, caricatures about his professional life. This is the form of humour known to Americans as 'self-kidding'. More than elsewhere, perhaps 'the laugh hides second thoughts about getting along together' (Bergson 1936 : 7). The partners wish to continue their relationship in spite of social barriers; the price they pay for this is to symbolically sacrifice social superiority by temporarily subjecting it to ridicule.

(b) *A*'s status is inconsistent, and this is a source of tension in the relationship. *A* and *B* have attained a similar educational level, but *A*'s professional position does not coincide with his level of education and is manifestly inferior to that of *B*. This difference is the source of a malaise which often comes through in conversations. The point is evaded in jokes about their common geographical origins. Parodying the regional accent reinforces a sense of complicity which helps overcome the differences perceived in their 'definitions of situations' in the sense of W.I. Thomas (*Case 14*).

(c) *A*'s status is superior to that of *B*, but neither partner excludes the possibility that their statuses will become equal in the near future. The perception of their present status inequality is affected by the anticipation of their potential equality. One result of this is a certain ambiguity in their exchanges. The management of these tensions results in a humour which suggests that the friends have attained the same social level. This social level is that of *A*; for *B* it is a reference group. *B*'s humour is in fact a form of anticipatory socialisation, which is amicably tolerated by *A*. In this case *A*'s is a 'welcoming laugh'. This is an interesting example of the cyclical relation between the friendly character of the relationship and joking. Humour allows the preservation of the relationship; *A*'s friendly disposition toward *B* leads him to tolerate with *B* a strategy which amounts to impression management in Goffman's sense of the words (*Case 19*).

4.3 *Role ambiguities*: Here we find, although in modified context, forms of interaction very similar to those observed in the avuncular relationship analysed by Radcliffe-Brown. Two cases are typical:

(a) *The mother's friend*: *A* and *B* have long been friends. *C* is *B*'s adult son. *A* knew *C* when he was a child, but, as a consequence of particular biographical circumstances, did not see him for several decades. Later they became friends. Between the mother's friend and the friend's son, there is nevertheless some role ambiguity: more specifically, *A* assumes roles which are sometimes difficult to reconcile. This is perceived by *C*. The result is a recurrent feeling of uneasiness which is overcome by joking. Laughter restores the feeling of complicity when it is threatened (*Case 3*).

(b) *The spouse's friend*: *A* and *B* have become friends. They are both married and, as often happens, have tended to transform the original dyadic relationship into a relationship between couples. *C*, *A*'s husband, is split between the traditional spouse's role, being careful to admit his wife's friend into his circle of acquaintances, and a certain reluctance as far as *B* is concerned. The balance of the relationship between the couples depends on a joking relationship between *B* and *C*. This relationship is asymmetrical. It is *C* who regularly pokes fun at *B* (*Case 15*).

In these two cases the reader will have noticed that role ambiguity results from an intrusion into a dyadic relationship by a third party who is, or who



becomes, a significant other (in the terms of G.H. Mead) for one of the original partners. Partly contradictory role-playing and role expectations thus interfere. Joking is used in this case as a strategy of tension reduction or as a strategy of avoidance. Joking can, in fact, be a way of eluding certain subjects of conversation one wishes to avoid.

*4.4 Norm conflicts:* Two examples, very different from each other, will be presented:

(a) *Reunions:* *A* and *B* see each other only occasionally because of *B*'s geographical mobility. As a result of all his travelling, *B* has turned 'cosmopolitan', whereas *A* has remained 'local', as described by Merton. The most notable difference is in regard to norms concerning making and receiving visits. *A* has a tendency towards formalism, whereas *B* is more spontaneous, and does not give much consideration to such things as the exigencies of reciprocity. *B* does, however, perceive *A*'s different orientation. Any embarrassment is neutralised by the use of humour when contact is taken up again, the pleasantries usually taking the form of telephone jokes. The absence of routine and of ritualisation, which might menace the relation, is replaced by a more or less conscious search for a 'welcoming laugh' (*Case 2*).

(b) *The importunate wife:* *A* and *B* have professional and intellectual interests in common. However, they rarely have the opportunity to see each other professionally any more, and occasionally meet during the evening at *B*'s home. In *A*'s mind, it would be normal for *B*'s wife, *C*, to leave them alone together. *C*, though, sees her hostess role differently, and thinks she should remain present. The result is a very complex triadic joking relationship, which in fact is comprised of three complementary diadic relationships. *A* mocks *C* as a way of expressing mitigated aggressiveness. *C* pokes fun at *A*, turning towards *B* to seek his connivance. *B* makes jokes, the object of which is to express, although prudently, veiled solidarity with *A*. The conversation slides bit by bit towards a peace-making and unifying level of humorous trifling (*Case 8*).

There are cases in which value- or status-heterophily combine with the wish to preserve the equilibrium of a broader *relationship network*. Three final cases of this type will be presented:

*Case 9:* *A* and *B* are volunteers (*mitnadvim*) in a kibbutz. Their friendship relationship is part of the much larger network of their peer group. In the social life of a kibbutz, relationships between peers are an extremely important form of sociability.<sup>6</sup> *A* and *B* have a lot in common. They have, however, reached very different conclusions about the perspectives offered by Zionist ideals. This cannot be seriously discussed, however, except by risking disruption within the group that offers a context for the relationship. This risk is never taken. The resulting frustrations are translated into sardonic humour in which the kibbutz is assimilated to a psychiatric hospital and its members to

patients whose delusion is that they are ... members of a kibbutz. There is an element here, more or less explicit, of ironic questioning of the protagonists' identity.<sup>7</sup>

*Case 12:* *A* and *B* are both consultants to an international organisation. Their relationship is supported by the periodic meetings of an international group of experts. Throughout the years the international working group has gradually become a network of cronies, united by multiple complicities. *A* and *B* differ as to the value to be conferred on the international projects in which they participate. Expressed brutally, their disagreement would shake the whole network. It is thus expressed harmlessly, in the form of cynical quips in which international civil servants and their consultants appear as swindlers. The old blades, directly affected, try to outdo one another. As long as this is all put in an ironic way, the system is not really threatened...

*Case 17:* *A* and *B* both hold university positions, although at different levels. They first met as tourists, and their relationship was thus at first one typical of vacations. Later on, *B* tried to enlarge the context of the relationship, while *A* did his best, on the contrary, to keep it within the limits of certain leisure roles. *A*'s wish to limit the relationship was never directed against *B*, but by his more general concern about keeping his professional life separate from his personal life. Nevertheless, two strategies were in opposition; one tried to maintain the equilibrium of a network by segmenting it, the other by integrating it. A joking relationship – in which the sallies are sometimes scathing – is born out of the confused perception of these differently appreciated strategies. This allows the contacts to go on in an ambiance in which joviality attenuates certain rancours.

In the first two cases the joking relationship is the expression of a *modus vivendi* which preserves both a dyadic relationship and the network into which the relationship is inserted. In the third case, on the other hand, the compromise represented by the joking relationship is part of a combined movement in which the very structure of the network is at stake. In all three cases, however, the particularities of the dyadic relation only become fully intelligible – as with the avuncular relationship analysed by Radcliffe-Brown – in the context of the overall network in which they are embedded. This network is the kinship system for the avuncular relationship, and the sociability network in the cases just discussed.

##### 5. *Elements of interpretation*

At this stage, we can perhaps make a first attempt at generalising and adapting to our own social reality the modes of reasoning inherited from the study of traditional societies. No matter what the context, the joking relationship, as we have seen, combines antagonism and attraction in a compromise formula which allows one to soften the other. This is true of kinship relationships, and it is also true of relationships in which a conflict of

values or a difference in statuses could rapidly eliminate all but antagonism. More generally, the joking relationship takes place within a strategy for reducing tensions between similarity and difference. It occurs in a situation of ambivalence in the sociological sense of the term, in which partners must assume roles adjusting to contradictory normative expectations (Merton 1976). A built-in component of such a situation is a tendency for attitudes to be unstable. In this situation, the joking relationship appears as a mode of regulation which ensures a certain predictability. In other words, it makes possible the adjustment of role expectations. This mode of regulation is institutionalised in traditional societies: in modern contexts it is more often left to the improvisation of the partners. The fundamental ambivalence of the situation is always linked to a form of marginality: marginality created by alliance in the patrilineal societies studied by Radcliffe-Brown, marginality generated by the heterophily of the relationship in the cases analysed above.<sup>8</sup> Beyond the ambivalence induced by structural conditions there is nevertheless – in our societies – a more profound ambiguity caused by tension between implicitly assumed homophily and actual heterophily. Joking is a way of coping with this tension. One might also interpret it as the reflection of a gap between the normative ideal of individualised friendship, involving the totality of the person, and the reality of our practices subject to psycho-social mechanisms having nothing to do with romantic idealisations.

Compared to the institutionalised and ritualised relationships of traditional societies, the personalised friendship relationships of the modern individual are precarious. The heterophilic relationships described above are, however, even more precarious. Humour is their stabilising element, but it is also humour, paradoxically, which can undermine their bases. There are several reasons for this. Joking amounts to a substitute for the taboo. Anything which might raise problems is rendered harmless with irony. This process is obviously in contradiction with the ideal of friendship in which joys and sorrows are shared in all spontaneity. The participants in the relation become prisoners of their own humour. The relationship can then succumb to its own dynamics. When the threat to it is a difference in status, humour becomes a weapon difficult to manipulate: while humour is used at all social levels, forms of humour vary according to *milieu*. A joke that tries to neutralise one source of tension can create another when partners have not internalised the same codes and do not necessarily consider the same things funny. In addition, certain forms of humour have a corrosive effect on the specificity of the dyadic relationship when they imply a process of typification, in Berger and Luckmann's (1966 : 46-47) sense of the term. Hence the danger of jokes using regional, national or ethnic stereotypes. The partner is robbed of uniqueness and rendered into the anonymity of a category based on ascribed characteristics. Finally, the very absence of institutionalisation is itself a risk factor for the relationship. Rituals imposed by a group tradition might be compared to handrails. When they are absent, partners develop their own rules of the game. But since these rules are tacit, the game is hazardous. A residue of normative

uncertainty subsists. Friends may bully each other playfully, but it requires a great deal of connivance to agree about what is acceptable and what is not. A comment which, taken literally, would be an insult, becomes acceptable as an innocent witticism only under appropriate circumstances. The limit is not always clear; moreover it will vary as a function of the context. A relationship, however, might not be able to survive repeated differences of perception in this respect. It was easier for the Dogons to insult one another, or for the Bangwa to throw excrement at each others' heads, before acculturation weakened the contexts of meaning, and the intentions of the participants became dubious (Brain : 1976).

If the joking relationship emerging from a heterophilic friendship is intrinsically precarious, it can also be brought to the point of rupture by exogenous factors. If, for example, one of the partners finds himself in a crisis situation, a distressing element is introduced into the relationship. Irony is generally maladapted to this new element. The gap between the reality of the relationship and the normative model to which it implicitly refers is clearly revealed in such a situation: the relationship seems to have gradually evolved towards an inadequate substitute, and the familiar old jokes no longer suffice to reestablish the indispensable feeling of complicity. The intervention of a third person can also bring about the rupture of a fragile equilibrium based on insider jokes. This is often the case when one of the partners gets married. Marriage is generally an event menacing to previous friendships; in a certain sense, indeed, the spouse can be said to enter into competition with friends in the hierarchy of preoccupations of the person who marries. This event is even more menacing for relationships cemented by a form of humour giving rise to connivance laughter. In *Les hommes de bonne volonté*, Jules Romains describes the insertion of a wife into a circle of old friends. In spite of the various turns in the careers of each, the group maintains an amicable atmosphere fostered by numerous jokes with long histories. The young wife plays the game superbly, adopting and being adopted by the group (1946, Vol. 27, Chapter 25). Reality is, however, not always as harmonious as the fiction produced by the author of *Les copains*. Finally, a third process can cause rupture. This is what we might call displacing the zone of taboos. In every relationship there are themes which are outside the limits of acceptable pleasantry. Some laughing matters are so delicate that even those who affect great cynicism do not take the risk of addressing them. Thus, for example, 'dirty Belgian' would be tolerable in a place where 'dirty Jew' would not. Jewish ethnic jokes unleash so many ghosts that people generally prefer to refrain from them. The realm of taboo subjects is a matter of mutual tacit adjustment. An event taking place in the life of one of the partners can make readjustment necessary. The bawdy jokes of joyous escapades will no longer be appropriate when one of the jolly fellows falls seriously in love. Gibes at a certain professional category will no longer seem sound when one of the friends receives a promotion into that profession. Variations in perception in this respect imply restructurations of identity. They require calling things in

question, and friendship does not always emerge intact. This is why, when a friendship is essentially a joking relationship, it is often linked to a certain phase of life. A certain form of humour had developed in a particular context. It seems that this sort of relationship only very occasionally outlives transplantation to a different context; rarely does it survive asynchronism of life courses or diversity of social destinies. New roles bring new definitions of situations. And nothing is as poignant as the buddy of yesterday, veteran comrade, who clings to the down-at-the-heels kidding only he still finds funny...

Some joking relationships are not only linked to a certain phase of life, but also arise in particular circumstances. This is the case, for example, for the requirements of a work environment or for a stay in a total institution. The forms of humour attached to these settings generally disappear with the conditions that brought them about. They nevertheless obey the general rules described above. In professional life, humour is often a safety valve, allowing the expression of a carefully mitigated antagonism, so as to preserve possibilities for cooperation. This is the case for the ironical exchanges noted by Pamela Bradney in a London department store (1957 : 179-187): antagonism is raised by a commission system of payment which encourages individual performance and indirectly penalises colleagues' helping one another. Acrimonious exchanges are, however, impossible since the salespeople are required to maintain a façade of courtesy in front of the customers. In these conditions humour makes it possible to release a certain dose of aggressiveness with some ambiguity. Joking is thus the barometer of the frustrations of those involved. A total institution, whether it be barracks, hospital or prison, is, of course, a completely different environment. In these surroundings we find specific forms of humour, born of the obligation to live with companions one has not chosen. Here, too, joking is a compromise formula between the irritation caused by others, and the necessity for a certain amount of acceptance. In such a context we find, in addition, other forms of humour, fruit of the anxiety provoked by a *milieu* which very directly menaces the individual's status and habits. This was described by Rose Laub Coser in her observations in a hospital environment (1959). Here some people clearly seek a 'welcoming laugh' by way of consolation.

#### 6. *Toward a combined approach*

Other observations relevant to the topic of this article were made in Africa among largely acculturated populations. They are of double interest. First, they allow us *a posteriori* to better understand the ancestral customs observed in traditional settings by studying them in a new context. They offer new points of comparison and new possibilities for assessing the value of interpretations previously suggested for them. In addition, however, they too demonstrate the permanence of certain social mechanisms. In doing this they help us combine ethnological and sociological points of view. A research project carried out some twenty years ago in Zambia by Kapferer (1969)

provides a good example. Observations were made among workers in a zinc mine. An incident reported by the author concerns workers in a surface workshop. Briefly stated, one of the workers is infringing an informal norm slowing the work rhythm. A dispute results (*ibid.* : 197 ff.). The turn taken by the conflict would be unintelligible to the outside observer if he or she were unaware that the joking relationship inherited from traditional life had been transported to the urban industrial context. Such relationships often maintain, at a benign level, antagonism which might otherwise degenerate. This was the case in the example in question. Because socially recognised joking relationships existed in the workshop, the conflict could be minimised under social pressure (*ibid.* : 212).

The persistence of tribal-based joking relationships in a transformed socio-cultural context, characterised mainly by increased geographical mobility, leads to normative uncertainties comparable to those observed in our own society. An anecdote related by Boswell (1969) illustrates this. During a brief stay in Lusaka, three rural authority councillors venture into a bar. They belong to different ethnies. The Chewa and the Bisa, who both had some experience with the urban environment, start joking together. The Lala seems disconcerted, worried about whether such behaviour is tolerable: in his village he would be obliged to fight anyone who was to address him in such a way. It is explained to him that all is as it should be, that the people from the Northern provinces normally establish joking relationships with those from the Eastern provinces. Our man, unfamiliar with life in the capital, was aware neither of the prevailing tribal classifications, nor of the forms of sociability associated with them. He was asking mainly to know what attitude to adopt in case he ever found himself in a similar situation (*ibid.* : 290). Who has never had a similar experience, in which one tries to classify someone in order to adapt behaviour in consequence? The criteria of classification vary; the attitude is fundamentally the same.

## 7. *Conclusion*

What is the underlying meaning of the approach adopted here? It is to be realised that pathways to discovery are not one-way. The observation of traditional societies, and the lessons we can learn from it, is an invaluable source of insights for the study of our own society. Customs, which at first seem disconcerting, can help shed new light on the daily interpersonal relations we can observe around us. But the analysis of the relations closest to us allow us – in return effect – to better understand the psycho-social mechanisms underlying the exotic practices which served as the point of departure for our reflections. Joking is one of these processes of interaction, whereby the human being selects between norms of behaviour available. The choice could have been for conflict or for retreat. But it was the ambiguity of humour which was chosen. It has been said that only human beings know how to say no (Scheler 1962). It has also been pointed out that they are the only animals knowing how to laugh (Bergson 1936). Rejecting a norm or dodging

it: this, it seems, is a constant option in human interaction. So far as one can put oneself in the place of another, in spite of cultural distance,<sup>9</sup> sociological and ethnological perspectives can truly *intermingle* rather than simply being juxtaposed. Is this not the path leading, according to the wishes of Lévi-Strauss, to 'the study of phenomena which render obvious certain *general properties of social life*' (1958 : 379, author's emphasis, translated from the French)? The matter involved here is the level of abstraction required to attain such general properties. This brings us to the problem of the relationship between model and reality, the problem, moreover, at the heart of the divergence between Radcliffe-Brown and Lévi-Strauss over the concept of structure (1958 : 333 and ss). In the end, the formalistic ambition of Simmel – reformulated in modern terms by Boudon (1984a : 208-9; 1984b : 21) – is perhaps not as illusory as one might have thought. Between nomothetical day-dreams and vain competition with history, today it is probably the 'narrow gate' opening to sociology.

### Notes

- <sup>1</sup> To deal immediately with a thorny question of vocabulary, the term 'ethnology' was used instead of anthropology in the French version of this paper, in accordance with the French Association of Anthropologists' use of ethnology as an equivalent to 'social and cultural anthropology' (see on this *Le Monde*, 20/21.4.80). It has been maintained in translation.
- <sup>2</sup> Here, methods should be distinguished from techniques. For Georges Granai, confusion on this point demonstrates a 'dangerous conceptual indigence' (1958 : 135). This is perhaps a bit cruel nor perhaps true in all cases. Nevertheless, the distinction has a very definite heuristic value.
- <sup>3</sup> I developed this in more detail in a course given at the Sociology Department of the University of Geneva during the academic year of 1983-1984. This is the opportunity to thank Christian Lalive d'Epinay, Professor at the University of Geneva, for the confidence he showed in allowing me to substitute for him during his sabbatical leave.
- <sup>4</sup> For a discussion of the role of ethnology in the evolution leading to modern sociological functionalism, see my book, *Le fonctionnalisme en sociologie: et après?* (1984a).
- <sup>5</sup> It should be noted here that the observations stretch over a period of more than ten years and were made in seven different countries: Austria, Belgium, France, Israel, the Netherlands, Rwanda and Switzerland. Some of the observations are still under way; others have been interrupted or no longer have an object. In other publications I have criticised the practice of drowning the reader with non-pertinent details (1984a : 197), and will avoid doing so here. The only relations between variables that ought to be taken into account are those to which meaning can be attached and which can be made plausible.
- <sup>6</sup> I have referred to these forms of sociability in previous publications (1980 : 208; 1984b : 177).
- <sup>7</sup> Problems of identity generally play an important role in Jewish humour. For discussions of this, see Zijderveld (1971 : 152 and ss) and the publications he cites.
- <sup>8</sup> The pertinence of the relationship between sociological ambivalence and marginality in this case was suggested to me by a recent publication by C.L. Kruitthof, University of Ghent (1984).
- <sup>9</sup> This is what Raymond Boudon calls the 'projective postulate'. He sees it as one of the elements of the neo-Weberian type of explanation. It seems to me that the conditions under which this postulate can be adopted remain open to discussion and qualification. This, in my opinion, is a crucial debate for the future of methodology in sociology. I refer here to a text Professor Boudon kindly made available to me before publication. For this I would like to express gratitude (see Boudon, forthcoming : 6-7).

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## ENCOUNTER BETWEEN ETHNOLOGY AND SOCIOLOGY

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